



REEL PARADISE

A Film by Steve James

Executive Producer Kevin Smith

Official Selection:
Sundance Film Festival
SXSW South By Southwest

English - 2005 - Color – 110 minutes

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REEL PARADISE

REEL PARADISE tells the extraordinary story of one American family's unique adventure running a cinema and showing free movies on a remote island in Fiji.

John Pierson is a noted independent film maven and author of the widely celebrated book *Spike, Mike, Slackers & Dykes*, who together with his wife Janet created the IFC cable show *Split Screen*. On one story for the show, John and his family went to Fiji in search of the 'world's most remote movie theater.'

John fell in love with Fiji's 180 Meridian Cinema when he saw the wild enthusiasm of the audience to a showing of the Three Stooges' *SOME MORE OF SAMOA* – a short they had been showing at the theater since it opened in 1954. "I'd never remotely heard anything like that," John says in REEL PARADISE. "This is somehow what I missed back when movies meant everything to people."

John decided he wanted to move with his family to Fiji and observe what movies meant to a country on the other side of the world. He also saw this adventure as a great opportunity to introduce his two kids, Georgia (16) and Wyatt (13), into a culture and lifestyle far different from that of their home in the New York City suburbs.

Filmed during the last month of the family's yearlong stay in Fiji, REEL PARADISE aims to reveal something of what the whole year has been like for the Piersons. The rural island of Taveuni is not one of Fiji's prime tourist destinations. Like most of the South Pacific islands, its people struggle to eke out a subsistence living as farmers, fisherman, and merchants. To the local Fijians, the Piersons were thought to be millionaires, because they were able to live in a large colonial home and show movies for free. (The home is indeed impressive by Fijian standards, though spartan by middle-class western standards.)

Georgia and Wyatt enroll in the local Catholic high school, where they are the only white students. They gamely throw themselves into this very different school environment where some view them as curiosities, and others as suspicious outsiders. The kids form friendships with some classmates, many of whom live in the nearby village of Natokalau, but come to treat the Pierson house as a second home. Janet follows their lead, befriending some of the families in the village.

John's village, says Janet, is the movie theater. John carries on the theater's tradition of showing a wide range of American, British and Hindi films. (The Fijian population is split between native Fijian islanders and Indo-Fijians whose ancestors immigrated there as indentured servants starting in the 1880s.) The profound difference now is John's ability to show the movies for free due to contributions from several independent filmmakers he had helped in the past. For many in Taveuni, going to movies had been impossibly expensive before the Piersons arrived. Now, the 180 Meridian Cinema becomes the focal point of entertainment on the island with frequently packed houses. John is able to secure many of the most current popular and blockbuster releases from America and abroad, everything from *RABBIT PROOF FENCE* and *BEND IT LIKE BECKHAM*, to *THE SCORPION KING* and *THE HOT CHICK*. For their last month in Fiji, John programs a special ten-day movie marathon featuring films like *MATRIX RELOADED*, *BRINGING DOWN THE HOUSE*, *APOCALYPSE NOW REDUX*, and *JACKASS*.

Because the Piersons are neither tourists nor permanent residents of Taveuni, their year here proves to be a complicated experience. They form strong friendships with locals like their cook Sia, and come to understand how third world islanders cope with day-to-day life. But they also experience culture clash and learn firsthand the realities of being “haves” in a culture of “have-nots.” Early in the film their home is robbed while they are out showing a movie. It’s the second such serious robbery since they’ve been in Fiji, and raises anew questions about whom they can trust or not trust. Their paranoia extends to their landlord Andrew, an Australian ex-patriot who lives on the property and has been a yearlong thorn in the side of the Pierson family. When Andrew insensitively presents the Pierson’s with a fuel bill the night of the second robbery, it strikes another blow against the notion that living here can be some kind of paradise.

As REEL PARADISE unfolds, we see the differing ways in which each of the Piersons deals with living in this very different culture. Showing movies for free makes John instantly famous as ‘Uncle John’ to the locals – especially those that could never afford to go to the movies otherwise. Yet, the free movies also bring John into direct conflict with some of the local Catholic priests, a battle he humorously characterizes as being for the “souls of the people of Taveuni.” Wyatt becomes a star pupil at school, praised repeatedly by teachers and administrators. But because the curriculum is not challenging for her, Georgia struggles with some of her teachers while forming a deep friendship with a local classmate named Miriama. School may be disappointing for her, but she clearly loves Fijian life.

The Piersons grant the filmmakers unusually intimate access to the family’s home life. The result is a frank portrait of a very American family abroad. We see the struggles between Georgia and her parents around typical issues for American 16 year-olds, now exacerbated by living in a culture in which children are never expected to talk back to parents. Yet Georgia’s friend Miriama prefers to stay with the Piersons instead of her own family -- where the father has been violent towards her and her mother. We also see that though Wyatt may be the quiet, obedient student at school, he can be a tough and ruthlessly funny critic of his father and mother at home. Through it all, we see Janet playing the role of peacekeeper, the voice of reason during a particularly tumultuous last month abroad.

By the end of the film, we see how the Piersons have both been changed and unchanged by their experience. As unusually candid subjects, the family does not sugarcoat their feelings towards each other or their experience in Fiji. But underneath it all, there is no mistaking their affection for both. The last movie in the ten-day marathon (and last scene in the film) captures the essence of what John went searching for in Fiji. He shows Buster Keaton’s classic, STEAMBOAT BILL JR. in part because he thought its climactic hurricane sequence would connect with the Fijians who had suffered through a devastating hurricane months earlier. The audience’s howls of laughter betray the sweet release that great comedy can bring to hard lives. John says, “You almost feel like it’s a cure for all that ails you. It was like nothing else matters anymore. All will be right with the world.”

CAST

**JOHN PIERSON
JANET PIERSON
GEORGIA PIERSON
WYATT PIERSON**

Georgia's Close Friend	MIRIAMA BIBI
The Landlord	ANDREW COGHILL
Wyatt's Best Friend	TAWAKE EVANS
Family Cook & Friend	TERESIA (SIA) GOPAL
Sia's Husband	PETERO GOPAL
Manager of Damodar Brothers	VIJEN NAIR
Friend & 180MC Attendee	KENI MADDEN
CSI Fiji	DETECTIVE NARAYAN
"Protects" John at Cinema	WAISAKO ROKOTUITAI
Projectionist	ELIA BIBI
AWOL Projectionist	NAMAJ & DOMINGO
Holy Cross Principal	MARCIA TABALALA
Primary School Headmaster	VILIMONE RAGIAWA
Georgia's Friend	LAVINIA TAYLOR
Tawake's Mother	VILISITA EVANS
Marist priest/Tutu Mission	FATHER BEN MCKENNA
Eldest Dayaram Son	SUBHASH CHANDRA
Middle Dayaram Son	DHANSUKH LAL
Patriarch who built 180MC	AMBARAN DAYARAM

CREW

Director	STEVE JAMES
Producers	STEVE JAMES SCOTT MOSIER
Executive Producers	KEVIN SMITH JANET PIERSON JOHN PIERSON P.H. O'BRIEN
Co-Producer/ Director of Photography	STEVE JAMES
Editor	NORMAN ARNOLD
Music Composer	AARON WICKENDEN
Associate Producer/ Post Production Supervisor	
Line Producer	GITA SAEDI
Location Sound	RICHARD K. POOLER
Online Editor	CYNDI MORAN
Music Supervisor	LINDA COHEN
Accountant	CHRIS KAHN
Additional Editing	AARON WICKENDEN
Stills Photographer	AMY C. ELLIOTT
Driver / Fixer	NAND LAL
Translators	KENI MADDEN
Production Assistance	TERESA DONOVAN MIRIAMA BIBI TUKS CAKAU PETERO GOPAL TERESA GOPAL WAISAKE ROKOTUITAI LAVINIA TAYLOR CELESTE NEUHAUS KARTEMQUIN FILMS AARON WICKENDEN JIM MORRISETTE ZAK PIPER LESLIE SIMMER MEDIA PROCESS GROUP, CHICAGO
Post Production Assistant	SKYWALKER SOUND
Offline Editing Suite	JUAN PERALTA
Assistant Editor	GARY RIZZO
Post Production	SLOSS LAW OFFICE
Technical Advisors	
Online Editing	
Post Production Sound	
Recording Mixers	
Legal Services	

Phase One Instigators

**ROBIN COWIE
GREGG HALE
MIKE MONELLO
DAN MYRICK
EDUARDO SANCHEZ
KEVIN SMITH
MATT STONE
DON WARD
CHRIS ZARPAS**

For making this film possible, the filmmakers gratefully acknowledge:

**JOHN PIERSON
JANET PIERSON
GEORGIA PIERSON
WYATT PIERSON
180 MERIDIEN CINEMA
THE PEOPLE OF TAVEUNI**

DIRECTOR'S STATEMENT

by Steve James

I'll never forget when John first called me about his adventure in Fiji after he'd returned from shooting that *Split Screen* episode at the 180 Meridian Cinema. He seemed almost as animated then as (I would later learn) he had been the night of the Three Stooges showing that spurred his epiphany. John told me of his plans to return for an extended period of time. He said he wanted to show the movies for free and that his family was going along. As he talked, each revelation seemed more fantastic than the previous one.

Then John hit me up for a donation to the cause. He did so gently, because he knew I was living (mostly) on a documentary filmmaker's income. He said he was asking filmmakers he had known or been involved with over the years. Some had leaped in with support (Kevin Smith, *South Park*'s Matt Stone, the Haxan Films/Blair Witch team), some had been bewildered (Michael Moore's six word email response had been, "Ugh, tell me this isn't happening.") and others had pleaded poverty. I pleaded poverty. I wished I could have helped. I'd met John while completing *HOOP DREAMS* in 1993. He didn't represent the film but he became an advisor who really beat the drum for it when we went to Sundance.

After the phone call, the next time I heard from John was at Sundance 2003 when my film *STEVIE* was at the festival. I was checking my emails and got one from him wishing me luck with the film. He then asked if I had any interest in directing a documentary on their experiences in Fiji. Like many others, I had sporadically followed the family's exploits in Fiji via their website, so I knew the broad strokes of the story. John told me in the email that Kevin Smith and partner Scott Mosier would be the executive producers and they'd secured the money to fund the film. I said to myself, "Let's see, a funded film where I get to go to Fiji and document a unique family's experience abroad showing free movies on a remote island?" It took me about three seconds to say yes.

Despite my ready enthusiasm, I had no interest in doing a vanity piece. Thankfully, John and Janet made it clear from the start that this would be my film, and they expected it to be as candid and honest as I could make it. That's not an easy thing to commit to for any subject of a documentary, let alone ones who are as media-savvy and self-aware as the Piersons.

But that is exactly what happened. Certainly one of the defining characteristics of *REEL PARADISE* is the honest - sometimes joyous, sometimes painful - depiction of their lives in Fiji. The film is neither a Pollyanna portrait of the Piersons nor, for that matter, of the Fijians. The film shows that life is hard there in differing ways for both the family and locals.

Though we filmed for only the last month, it was a full one. In addition to the ten-movie marathon, there's the delinquent projectionist, the robbery, dengue fever, and those family conflicts. The film also presented me with an opportunity to get to know some of the Fijian people in the Piersons' lives. Then there were the audiences at the movies. Nowhere in the world have I seen such visceral and passionate responses to a movie. In *REEL PARADISE*, we really tried to capture the experience inside that theater. Being there, I realized why John had been so affected by his first visit to the 180 Meridian Theater, and why he wanted so badly to come back.

Yet despite the richness of that month of shooting, it's true that no film can fully capture a subject's experience. My *modus operandi* on my previous films (including the recent miniseries on immigrants in America, THE NEW AMERICANS) is to shoot for years at a time. Indeed, for this film, I could have easily imagined myself shooting periodically over the entire year of their stay. But that wasn't possible because funding came later. And in fact, it wasn't desirable either for the Piersons. They needed to spend the bulk of their time in Fiji just living their lives, without the camera.

I like to think of my films as acts of discovery. I may start with a solid idea or expectation of where the story is headed. But every time, the story ends up taking me in a different direction. That's the powerful allure of documentary filmmaking: to let the subjects and the story dictate the direction of the film, not the other way around.

For example, going in I had greater expectations that the film would explore the meaning of free movies on the locals. But what I found was that impact and meaning are hard things to quantify or even articulate in a culture where English is a second language and many of those in attendance are either not formally educated or young students. (Which only made me turn the question back on America. Despite our media inundated culture, greater wealth and education, we still have no real idea how to quantify the impact of movies here at home. It remains a source of huge debate.)

What did emerge for me was a story about a family abroad and the how each member of that family coped with and was changed (or not changed) by their Fijian experience. The Pierson family became a kind of metaphor for the differing ways America is in the world. John is a larger than life figure; a man on a mission in the quintessential American sense. His mission is movies, sometimes in opposition to that of the church there. Janet is in many ways John's mirror opposite. If John is the American proselytizer, Janet is the American diplomat. Georgia may struggle with authority at home and school, yet she displayed absolute ease with Fijian culture and kids of all ages. And despite Wyatt's great ability to adapt to the local culture, he was still very much his father's son.

Making REEL PARADISE was an extremely provocative, at times funny, and other times enlightening experience. It is my hope that we have made such a film.

FIJI FACTS

- Fiji consists of 323 islands in the Pacific Ocean just over the International Dateline and slightly below the equator in the Southern Hemisphere — meaning that it's already tomorrow, and it's winter.
- Because it's tropical, you wouldn't know it was winter, spring, summer, or fall. It's permanently hot and wet. Days and nights are always about 12 hours long.
- Fiji has been an independent republic since 1970 with a parliamentary government. It was a British colony before then.
- Early colonial-era missionaries pacified the warrior Fijians who had once practiced cannibalism. In fact Fiji was once called the Cannibal Isles.
- The British colonists brought in Indian labor for the sugar plantations, so Fiji has a large minority Indo-Fijian population with its own culture. They cannot own tribal land.
- English is a second (or even third, after Hindi) language. But it is still indisputably the language in school. And literacy rates, on paper at least, are surprisingly high.
- The most recent coup was in May 2000 not long after the Piersons' initial *Split Screen* visit. That fourth coup, by nativist Fijians, overturned a legitimately elected Indian prime minister.
- Taveuni is the third largest island in Fiji. But it's still only 25 miles long and 8 miles wide — a cigar shape. A volcanic ridge down the middle divides the wild, unoccupied ocean side from the sheltered part where almost all the villages (and the 180 Meridian Cinema) are located.
- Taveuni's population is reportedly about 10,000 in a string of villages along the one mostly dirt road. Perhaps 2,000-3,000 residents are within a 5km walking distance of the cinema. The buses don't run after dark. There are only 409 registered vehicles.
- Taveuni is the Garden Island, rural even by Fijian standards. The cash crops are dalo (taro), copra (coconuts) and kava (a narcotic root). There is no public electricity. Merchants, ex-pats and a few others have generators.
- Village social life centers around the grog bowl. Grog is the brownish fluid that results when you pound the kava root into a powder and then strain water through it. (Other islands chew it and spit it out first.) Men and women, but mainly men, drink it communally in a semi-ritualistic manner for many hours each night. It's numbing.
- Taveuni has two chiefs, the Tui Cakau (pronounced Tooey The Cow) and the Tui Vuna. They control the mataqalis which collectively own or lease the land. In all of Fiji, the Fijians retain ownership of 83% of the land.
- Although the Methodists wielded the greatest missionary influence across Fiji, the Catholics have had a historic stronghold on Taveuni — both regular Catholics and the

more doctrinaire (and anti-free movie) Marist Brothers. Taveuni also has Mormons, Jehovah's Witnesses and Seventh Day Adventists.

- Fiji has one television station, Fiji 1. Each Taveuni village has one television. Everyone gathers on Friday evening for the top-rated show, *Walker: Texas Ranger*.
- Rupert Murdoch owns the major newspaper, the *Fiji Times*. It's a good-hearted, unifying, liberal publication. It has no film critic.
- The Damodar Brothers (some call them the Fijian Weinsteins) are the only English-language film distributors. They import titles from all the Hollywood studios and the British Commonwealth. They are based in the capital city of Suva on the big island Viti Levu where they also operate the fabulous Village 6 multiplex.
- Many films at the Village 6 open day & date with the U.S. Because of the dateline, this can actually mean a day ahead of the U.S. The reason is that piracy in Fiji is rampant and almost every title is bootlegged with impunity within a short time. So the studios make hay during the short window.
- The 180 Meridian Cinema was built by Ambaran Dayaram and opened in 1954 with Burt Lancaster's *HIS MAJESTY O'KEEFE*, which was filmed in Fiji. Ambaran's middle son Dhansukh Lal ran the theater for 30 years before emigrating to New Zealand in 2002.
- Movies used to cost \$2 Fijian which used to be about \$1 U.S. Attendance had sagged due to video (available to the wealthy Indians) and a depressed local agricultural economy.
- In the 60's, aside from the Hindi films, John Wayne, Elvis Presley and *THE SOUND OF MUSIC* ruled. In recent times, old school action idols like Van Damme, Seagal, Stallone and Norris continue to be gods.
- The island that Mel Gibson recently bought is in the Lau Group east of Taveuni on the way to Tonga. Malcolm Forbes's ashes are scattered on his beloved private island Laucala just north of Taveuni. Many Hollywood and Australian superstars like to luxuriate at the very exclusive Wakaya Club 100 miles southwest of Taveuni.

180 MERIDIAN CINEMA -- THE YEAR IN PICTURES

All Movies Shown For Free (alphabetical)

28 DAYS LATER	MOHABBATEIN (India)
8 MILE	MONSTERS INC
ACCIDENTAL SPY, THE (w/ Jackie Chan)	MY BIG FAT GREEK WEDDING
ALI	NATIONAL SECURITY
APOCALYPSE NOW REDUX	NURSE IS WORSE (Three Stooges)
AUSTIN POWERS IN GOLDMEMBER	OCEANS II
BABY BOY	PANIC ROOM
BAD COMPANY	RABBIT-PROOF FENCE
BEND IT LIKE BECKHAM	ROCK STAR
BLACKHAWK DOWN	SCORPION KING, THE
BOURNE IDENTITY, THE	SHANGHAI KNIGHTS
BRINGING DOWN THE HOUSE	SIGNS
CATCH ME IF YOU CAN	SOME MORE OF SAMOA (Three Stooges)
CHICAGO	SORORITY BOYS
CORE, THE	SPIDER-MAN
CRADLE 2 THE GRAVE	SPY KIDS
CROSSROADS	STEAMBOAT BILL JR.
DARKNESS FALLS	STUART LITTLE 2
DEVDAAS (India)	THE ONE (w/ Jet Li)
DIE ANOTHER DAY	TRAINING DAY
DON'T SAY A WORD	TUXEDO, THE
DRUNKEN MASTER II	TWO WEEKS NOTICE
E.T.	UNDERCOVER BROTHER
ENOUGH	X-2
FAST AND THE FURIOUS, THE	XXX
GANGS OF NEW YORK	
HARRY POTTER AND THE CHAMBER OF SECRETS	
HARRY POTTER AND THE SORCERER'S STONE	
HOT CHICK, THE	
HUMRAAZ (India)	
ICE AGE	
INSOMNIA	
JACKASS	
JOHNNY ENGLISH	
JUWANNA MANN	
KAANTE (India)	
KABHI KHUSHI KABHIE GHAM (India)	
LAGAAN (India)	
LIKE MIKE	
LORD OF THE RINGS: THE FELLOWSHIP OF THE RINGS	
LORD OF THE RINGS: THE TWO TOWERS	
MAID IN MANHATTAN	
MATRIX RELOADED, THE	
MATRIX, THE	
MEN IN BLACK II	

THE FILMMAKERS

STEVE JAMES (director, producer, editor) is best known as the award-winning director, producer, and co-editor of *HOOP DREAMS*, which swept every major documentary award of 1994, including the Robert F. Kennedy Journalism Award and the Peabody Award. James recently served as an executive producer, story director, and series editor on *THE NEW AMERICANS*, a seven-hour miniseries on the lives of contemporary immigrants that aired to critical acclaim on PBS in 2004. The series won two Golden Hugos at the Chicago International Television Festival and recently won the 2004 Independent Documentary Association Award for Best Limited Series for Television.

In 2002, James produced, directed and edited *STEVIE*, which won the coveted grand jury prizes at the International Documentary Film Festival in Amsterdam and the Philadelphia Film Festival, and won major prizes at the 2003 Sundance Film Festival and the Yamagata International Documentary Film Festival. The acclaimed film was released theatrically and landed on more than a dozen "Ten Best Films of 2003" lists.

SCOTT MOSIER (producer) is the house producer of Kevin Smith's New Jersey-based production company, View Askew Productions (home to their New Jersey series: *CLERKS*, *JAY AND SILENT BOB STRIKE BACK* and *JERSEY GIRL*). Scott has edited all but one of this series of films (*MALLRATS*).

Scott Mosier has also executive produced four micro-budget features under the View Askew banner: *VULGAR*, a Lions Gate release for spring 2002, *A BETTER PLACE*, *DRAWING FLIES*, and *BIG HELIUM DOG*. He has also produced a series of MTV commercial spots starring Jay and Silent Bob (re-occurring characters in Smith's movies). Mosier also co-executive produced, with Smith, the Academy Award winning film *GOOD WILL HUNTING*. With Smith, Mosier also executive produced with Miramax and Disney animation, *The Clerks Animated Television Show* for ABC prime-time television. Mosier and Smith continue to help independent filmmakers on the path to their own feature film careers.

KEVIN SMITH (executive producer) In the few years since his entry into the indie film community, Kevin Smith has seen it all - from the surprise critical and commercial success he received for his debut film *CLERKS*, to the disappointing critical and commercial drubbing he took on his second outing *MALLRATS*. He caught a break on his third film, the critically hailed *CHASING AMY*, and managed not to get killed by the religious zealots over his fourth film, the comedic spiritual meditation *DOGMA*. With the aptly titled *JAY AND SILENT BOB STRIKE BACK*, Smith wrapped up the five-film "Jersey Trilogy" and headed for more grown up territory with *JERSEY GIRL*.

As for the hood ornaments he's collected, there's plenty of tin to go around: the Filmmaker's Trophy at Sundance for *CLERKS*; the Prix de la Jeunesse and the International Critic's Week Award at the Cannes Film Festival, also for *CLERKS*; The Independent Spirit Award for Best Screenplay for *CHASING AMY*, and a Humanitas Award for *GOOD WILL HUNTING*. The Video Software Dealer's Association named him Visionary of the Year for his longtime commitment to the DVD format and sales success in the field. Smith also received the Defender of Democracy Award from Norman Lear's People for the American Way

organization for his production of DOGMA. For his writing in the comics field, Smith has received a Harvey Award, a Wizard Fan Award, an Eagle Award, and had *Green Arrow: Quiver* named as one of 2003's Best Books for Young Adults by the American Library Association's Young Adult Library Service. In the fall of 2002, the town of Paulsboro, NJ named a street after him: Kevin Smith Way.

JOHN PIERSON (executive producer, subject) graduated from NYU Film School in January 1977. Twenty-five years later, he left America behind to show free movies at the world's most remote theater, Fiji's 180 Meridian Cinema. In between, he played many pivotal roles in bringing the work of first-time filmmakers like Spike Lee, Michael Moore, Kevin Smith and Richard Linklater to the screen, a portfolio that *Premiere* called "a virtual hit parade of the independent movement." These tales are chronicled in John's book *Spike, Mike, Slackers & Dykes: A Guided Tour Across a Decade of American Independent Cinema*, revised and reissued in 2004 as *Spike Mike Reloaded*. Peter Biskind calls it "the bible for independents."

He was also creator and host of *Split Screen*, a half-hour magazine-format television show on IFC. Over its four year run, *Split Screen* spawned features ranging from THE BLAIR WITCH PROJECT to HOW'S YOUR NEWS? Often in partnership with his wife and Grainy Pictures co-president Janet Pierson, John has directed film festivals, staged annual film workshops, and formed a completion funding company. He also executive produced CHASING AMY and once acted opposite Chris Noth. In addition, he recently appeared on Real World Austin as the guy who assigns the kids their 'job.'

The Piersons now live in Austin, TX where John teaches in the UT film department and is preparing a *Split Screen* box set with Aspyr Media.

JANET PIERSON (executive producer, subject), co-president of Grainy Pictures, has partnered with her husband John Pierson professionally since 1986. In 2002-2003, they showed free movies at the world's most remote cinema in Taveuni, Fiji. She was co-creator, executive producer and occasional segment director of their magazine-format cable television series, *Split Screen*. Earlier projects include staging the Cold Spring Film Workshop and serving as producer reps and/or investors in over two dozen original American independent features like SHE'S GOTTA HAVE IT, ROGER & ME, SLACKER, and CLERKS. From 1981 to 1986 she was assistant director of NYC's Film Forum. In 1977-1979 she ran Canyon Cinema Cooperative in S.F. She attended Hampshire College, graduating with a BFA from the San Francisco Art Institute in 1977. Having recently relocated to Austin with her family, Janet is now on the board of the Austin Film Society.

P.H. O'BRIEN (co-producer, director of photography) has been a writer, producer, director and cinematographer for the past ten years. P.H. worked as a producer/director for John Pierson's acclaimed TV show, *Split Screen*, which aired on the Independent Film Channel (IFC) for four years. He wore several hats as a part of HOW'S YOUR NEWS? documentary that aired on Cinemax and PBS after debuting at the 2001 Toronto Film Festival. A second HOW'S YOUR NEWS? feature, focusing on the American political process is currently in post-production. He has also produced and shot shows for American Movie Classics, the BBC, History Channel and Lifetime. P.H. has written and is currently in pre-production on a narrative feature called ROUTE 1 to be directed by him in 2005. He lives in North Reading,

Massachusetts where he enjoys watching movies, moving and restoring pre-1900 buildings, eating Japanese food and Oreos and occasionally running a 24-hour towing business.

AARON WICKENDEN (associate producer) began his professional career in the medium of still photography. He parlayed a job in Print Viewing at the Center for Creative Photography into internships with Richard Avedon and Annie Leibovitz. His interest in documentary film grew from an internship with Peter Broderick's Next Wave Films where he helped to coordinate the grass roots publicity campaign for the award-winning doc FIGHTER. After relocating to Chicago in 2002, Aaron became the Post Production Coordinator on Kartemquin Films' award winning series THE NEW AMERICANS. He is currently working as the assistant editor on Deborah Scranton's untitled documentary on soldiers in Iraq.

GITA SAEDI (line producer) is an award-winning independent documentary Producer/Director/Editor who has been working in film for over 15 years. She most recently served as the Series Producer for the PBS national series THE NEW AMERICANS, a 3-part, 7 hour series following five immigrant families in the U.S. Prior to THE NEW AMERICANS, she served on producing teams for Channel 4 in the UK, CBS and PBS in the U.S. and RTE in Ireland. Saedi currently lives in Montana with her husband where she is producing a multi-part series on Montana history for the state and pursuing new projects.

PIERSON FAMILY Q&A

How'd you get your films?

JOHN: Mostly we showed what we thought were the best, or most likely to succeed, titles that were already in Fiji and approved by the Censor Board. The only way to import prints would've been through the US Embassy, and they weren't interested

What were the audiences' favorites?

JOHN: SCORPION KING. Anything with J.Lo. BEND IT LIKE BECKHAM.

GEORGIA: They laughed their asses off at guys in drag, like in THE HOT CHICK or SORORITY BOYS.

WYATT: But sometimes Dad would show a movie that only he liked, and that didn't work. Like APOCALYPSE NOW REDUX. People were sleeping. I always said it should've been "reduxed" by 90 minutes.

GEORGIA: Dad talks about how RABBIT PROOF FENCE did well. We think maybe it was because there was a bunch of walking in it. People in Fiji walk everywhere, so they could relate.

What's going on with the cinema now?

JOHN: Still closed. When I call Taveuni, the people wish the movies were playing. The kids went back alone last year.

WYATT: We saw some sort of religious services inside.

JOHN: That's poetic justice. I've offered my fat set of keys to festival audiences starting at Sundance, and I've had about six takers. But that place is not easy to operate, not to mention the fact that the lease for the land under the cinema is in dispute.

What are the kids doing now?

WYATT: I'm in public high school in Austin, TX starting 10th grade, which is the equivalent grade I was in at Holy Cross in Fiji two years ago.

GEORGIA: I graduated from high school, my seventh, in Austin. I've been working at Landmark's Dobie Theater since Christmas, and I just started culinary school at the Culinary Academy of Austin.

How'd you feel about allowing yourself to be filmed?

JANET: I know the film has me saying NO at the outset, but the rest of the sentence was that I took a deep breath, thought of all the documentary films that have meant so much to me over the last 30+ years, like HOOP DREAMS, the films of Rob Epstein, SOUTHERN COMFORT—films where the subjects really had something to lose and I knew I had to allow ourselves to be part of it. No one's more honest and open than we are – I knew that could be really useful. And I also understood what a really good story it was.

WYATT: I didn't think anyone was going to watch it, so I really didn't care.

JOHN: What was important to me was sharing the experience of seeing movies at the 180. It was magical. I thought having dengue during filming was pretty awful, but it's not really a big deal in the film.

You know so many documentary filmmakers, why Steve James?

JOHN: Steve was always on the top of our short list. And Chris Smith too. Good directors, standup human beings.

JANET: Besides loving Steve's work, it was important to me how much he appreciates being married and loves his own kids. I believed he's a filmmaker that's sensitive to all his subjects, not at all condescending. And it meant a great deal too that PH O'Brien, our longtime friend and *Split Screen* collaborator was going to shoot the film. He'd been with us on our initial trip for *Split Screen* in Feb. 2000. Then he came over and spent a month before the shoot just hanging out and experiencing Fijian life.

What was it like being filmed?

JANET: Ironically in 24 hours I went from "I'm not comfortable being filmed" to "they're not filming me!" There was one camera, and four principals, not to mention the Fijians. There was only so much the camera could cover. And what's surprising too, is that people always assume the cameras are intrusive, when actually there was this instinct to share our experience with them. You know, like "Can you believe this? Check that out!"

GEORGIA: More than how we changed, I think it changed how the Fijians acted. They'd kind of stay away, and they wouldn't speak English to the camera. Everything happened, but I think things would have happened differently if the camera hadn't been there.

Was it hard coming back?

JANET: No. Electricity's pretty easy to get used to.

WYATT: I think now I see things more openly. Or at least I notice more how close-minded other people are.

GEORGIA: It's a lot colder and less friendly here. Everyone you see in Fiji smiles and says hi to you. Hitchhiking is a major method of transportation. You could really live for free there.

People feed you, everyone shares everything, and you can fall asleep in the middle of a field and no one messes with you. You can't really do that here very easily.

How were you changed by this?

WYATT: My sister and I get along much better now. We weren't close before, but in Fiji there was no one else who really spoke English and who could understand all the funny things.

JANET: I think we're all less materialistic. We buy less. And I know we're a stronger family because of both living in Fiji and making the film. We understand now what it's like to be documentary subjects. The kids have been very thoughtful and smart and understanding about this whole process.

JOHN: Instead of having a family fight, now we can all gang up on Steve instead.

Has Georgia been in touch with Miriama?

GEORGIA: When Wyatt and I went back last year we saw everyone. She's still in the same grade turning in my work from the previous year -- doing very well I might add. I got one letter from Miriama but it's hard to stay in touch. 70 cents for postage there is as hard to come by as the motivation to write a letter here.

From your perspective now, would you have done anything differently?

JANET: I would have hired someone to act as security in the house the minute the film crew arrived. I'd meant to, and just got distracted. Avoiding that robbery could have really changed the last month. I'd expected a lovely sentimental leave-taking, instead I was counting the minutes to get off the island without more mishaps.

GEORGIA: Absolutely. I probably would have avoided the camera even more, it only attracted drama.

Have the Fijians seen the film?

WYATT: No, they'd hate it. They might like seeing themselves at first, but there's too much talking.

JANET: We had two Fijians at the first screening in Sundance. One is Keni Madden who's in the film. The other is Dan Bolea, the head of the Fiji Audio Visual Commission. Dan felt it was a very honest portrait. Then we had more Fijians in the screenings in Salt Lake City -- there's a community of Fijians who've become Mormons there -- they totally embraced it. But in Fiji itself, it would probably be a different story because of the language.

Did you learn the language?

WYATT: No, it was too hard.

GEORGIA: I understood a lot but always responded in English.

JOHN: Let me interject here – English is the language of education. There has never been a movie made in Fijian, dubbed in Fijian, or subtitled in Fijian. English, or Hindi, is the language of the movies.

Did you have any say in the editing?

JOHN: Steve worked by himself until he had a rough cut of about 2 1/2 hours. Then he showed it to us. The first day, maybe week, was traumatic. I think we went at it hot & heavy for about a month until a test screening with an audience of 100 helped everyone focus on the film's strengths and weaknesses. Georgia & I really took some heat that night.

GEORGIA: Editing makes everything look a lot more extreme. There's always the question of why I'm a bastard that comes up in terms of the family seeming dysfunctional. The stuff they put in the movie does make me seem like an asshole. And I did it, and I'd probably do it again. But it's completely out of context. Maybe there's stuff that I did that could have been shown that if you saw it I'd redeem myself a little more, you know? I can't deny that anything happened but people need to understand characters are developed to fit the flow of the movie.

Any audience friction so far?

JOHN: Not so much in 14 festivals, except...

GEORGIA: When we went to Portland that was the coolest thing ever. At Sundance everything was smooth, everyone was nice, and things were natural and we could kind of just giggle about everything. But at Portland, there were these crazy, righteous people that just hated it. They'd stand up and give a long speech about how we should have taken sensitivity training before we went or something. They were like, "Boo to you guys for ruining the world!" And we were just going to live there for a year, and most of the stuff we showed had already made it there on bootlegs. We weren't forcing people to come to the movies. We were just making them available. We were easily avoided.

WYATT: Sometimes people are really unfair to Georgia. Like after the SXSW screening, we were sitting waiting to do the Q&A and a woman came outside and said, "If she was my daughter I would have slapped her upside the head."

THANKS

Aminah Abdul-Jillil	Warren Dern
Rowan Atkinson	James Dorgan
Andy Bandit	Noreen Dziwulski
Brianna Barcus	Peer Ebbighausen
Joshua Baur	Jacqueline Eckhous
Vini Bennett	
Phil Benson	Dave England
Halle Berry	Devin Flynn
Allison Binder	Casandra Franceschi
Jason Bitner	Jackie Fuchs
Alison Bourke	David Gale
Julian Bratolyueov	Paul Garcia
Faida Amana Brigham	Jennifer Gaylord Rohrer
Pam Brockie	Richard Gere
Dev Chatillon	Craig Giummarra
Brent Cox	Clive Graham
Oliver Ford Davies	Curtis Hanson
Matt Harvey	Josh Meakim
Bob Hercules	Ben Miller
Tommy Redmond Hicks	Daniel Moore
Hugh Jackman	Brittany Murphy
Janna Johnson	Tom Naughton
Spike Jonze	Terese Olsen
Christie Jordan	Gary Palmucci
Johnny Knoxville	Ted Passon
Sharmalee B. Lall	Doug Pensak
Preston Lacy	Chris Pontius
Tim Lanza	Anita Prentice
Queen Latifah	Missi Pyle
Spike Lee	Gordon Quinn
Claire Lincoln	Claire Raskind
Ed Limato	Chris Raab
Roni Lubliner	Tim Rivelli
Lou Mallozzi	Rebecca Romijn-Stamos
James Marsden	Tom Rothman
Steve Martin	David O. Russell
Stephanie Martinelli	Frank Sacco
Ehren McGhehey	Carol Schaffner
Molly McIntyre	Bryan Searing
Amy McNaughton	David Simpson
	Adam Singer
	John Sloss
	Chris Smith
	Jennifer Schwalbach Smith
	Peter Strand
	Rachel Tansuche
	Nicolas Valcour
	Jessica Wolfson

VINAKA

J. Balelcakam	Waga Bibi
Anna Bibi	Narendra Chand
Elia Bibi	Salo Chana
Elisabeta Bibi	Bina Chand
Miriama Bibi	Sudesh Chand
Babu Chawada	Subhash Chandra
Andrew Coghill	Rob Park
Bruce Delai	Chandrika Prasad
Alumeci Evans	Dinesh Prasad
Joseph Evans	Michael Prasad
Lavinia Evans	Pita Radio
Sake Evans	Vilimone Ragiawa
Sisilia Evans	Reme Ravia
Tawake Evans	Waisake Rokotuitai
Vilisita Evans	Ronald Sami
Yale Evans	Mary Saumi
Petero Gopal	Vilitati Savirio
Teresia Gopal	Anil Shankaran
Father Lewis Henry	Atish Shankaran
Robert Leonard Koroi	John Shankaran
Father Kosi	Nanise Aba Sharndil
Chandra Kumari	Marcia Tambalala
Nand Lal	Lavinia Taylor
Jacqueline	Low Patrick Taylor
Father Ben McKenna	Tekaie Tioruakavo
Ramesh Mishra	Noa Tokavou
Eliza Nair	Vinod Trikam
Vijendra Nair	Eseta Tulavu
Dan Negoianu	Berenadeta Veitoyaki
Brother Simon O'Connor	Tino Vereti
Gerard O'Brien	Fabiano Vovokyro
	Sam Wakehm

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Barry Littman
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Joe Rangel
Andrea Scharf
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Air Fiji, Byron & Cyril
C.D.P. Services, Ltd.
Directors Guild of America
Fiji AudioVisual Commission,
Taniela Bolea, Bulou Coka, & Wayne Covell
Fiji Water, Ian Lincolne
Garden Island Resort
Garden Island Resort Band
Holly Cross Catholic Parish
Holy Cross College
Macworks Suva, Stefan Ali
New Dominion Pictures
Screen Actors Guild
Suva Motor Inn
The Village of Natokalau
The Village of Wairiki

GRAINY PICTURES WEBMASTER

Ming Chen

SONGS

"Chookar Mere Man Ko"
Written by Anjaan Rajesh Roshan
Performed by The Garden Island Resort Band
Courtesy of South Pacific Recordings, Ltd.

"Crazy Rap"
Written by Joseph Foreman
Performed by Miriama Bibi and Georgia Pierson

"Isa Noqu Dauloman"
Written by Petero Logalaca
Performed by The Garden Island Resort Band
Courtesy of South Pacific Recordings, Ltd.

"Can You See Me"
Written by Adam Green
Performed by Adam Green
Courtesy of Rough Trade / Sanctuary Records Group

"Ich Bein Ein Manipulator"
Written by Devin Flynn
Performed by Devin Flynn
Courtesy of Devin Flynn

"Roxie"
Written by Fred Ebb and John Kander
Performed by Renée Zellweger
Courtesy of Miramax Films

"We Both Reached For The Gun"
Written by Fred Ebb and John Kander
Performed by Renée Zellweger and Richard Gere
Courtesy of Miramax Films

"Stop Dreamin"
Written by Albert Spaulding, Casey Bridgeford and
Sheronn Hooks
Performed by DaFilled
Courtesy of Adim Management

"Pate Pate"
Written by Opetai'a Foa'i and Malcolm Smith
Performed by Te Vaka
Courtesy of Warm Earth Records

"Isa Na Bula"
Written by Petero Logalaca

Performed by The Garden Island Resort Band
Courtesy of South Pacific Recordings, Ltd.

"Luvuci Au (A Love Song)"
Written by Petero Logalaca
Performed by The Garden Island Resort Band
Courtesy of South Pacific Recordings, Ltd.

ADDITIONAL FOOTAGE

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